

▲ *Jul. 28, 2008*

The Power Broker

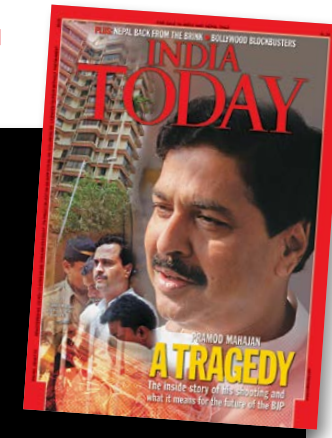
Amar Singh emerged as the UPA era's most formidable power broker, operating in the shadows where numbers, access and survival mattered more than ideology. As SP general secretary and RS MP, he became indispensable during moments of political crisis... when he played a decisive role in saving the Manmohan government during the trust vote triggered by the Indo-US N-deal.



▲ *Sept. 5, 2005*

Red Roadblock

Prakash Karat became the UPA's most consequential internal obstacle, wielding disproportionate influence without holding office. As CPI(M) general secretary, he used the Left's outside support to police the government's economic and foreign policy, repeatedly forcing reversals on disinvestment, FDI, strategic reforms and US engagement. Karat treated the UPA as a suspect deviation from socialist orthodoxy, insisting on rigid adherence to the NCMP.



▲ *May 8, 2006*

The Tragic End

During the Vajpayee years, Pramod Mahajan shaped alliances, modernised the BJP's outreach and emerged as a national-level troubleshooter. In April 2006, he was shot at his Mumbai home by his younger brother and died days later. His sudden death stunned Indian politics, abruptly ending the rise of a leader widely seen as a future power centre.



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"No One Can Stop Me From Becoming PM"
Aug. 18, 2008

"And they (my political rivals) have seen what a good government I have given in UP, so they are scared that if the BSP forms a government at the Centre and Mayawati becomes PM, they will have to wait for a long time to come back to power at the Centre. That is why they thought it is better we don't let her come to power at all...a movement has begun. When the time comes, no one can stop. No one could stop me from becoming the chief minister of UP."

survival often depended less on ideology than on intermediaries who could deliver numbers at critical moments.

Prakash Karat represented another kind of unelected power. As the CPI(M)'s general secretary, he exercised disproportionate influence over national policy while remaining insulated from electoral accountability. His ideological rigidity repeatedly stalled reforms and ultimately led to the Left withdrawing support over the Indo-US nuclear deal. In doing so, he not only weakened the UPA but also accelerated the Left's own decline by disconnecting it from a rapidly changing electorate.

The period also witnessed tragedy that symbolised the volatility of high politics. Pramod Mahajan's death in 2006 abruptly ended the career of one of the BJP's most agile strategists, creating a vacuum that reshaped the party's internal balance at a critical juncture. His absence altered succession dynamics and reminded Delhi of how fragile political ascendancies could be.

THE DECADE BECAME A CRUCIBLE IN WHICH INDIA'S FEDERAL POLITICS HARDENED INTO A NEW REALITY, ONE WHERE POWER FLOWED UPWARDS

Taken together, these years marked the end of an era when national parties could dictate terms to the states. Regional leaders no longer sought validation from Delhi; rather Delhi sought survival through them. The period became a crucible in which India's federal politics hardened into a new reality, one where power flowed upwards from the states, often fragmenting authority at the Centre. The rise of regional stalwarts became the structural prelude to the more centralised counter-reaction that followed in 2014. ■